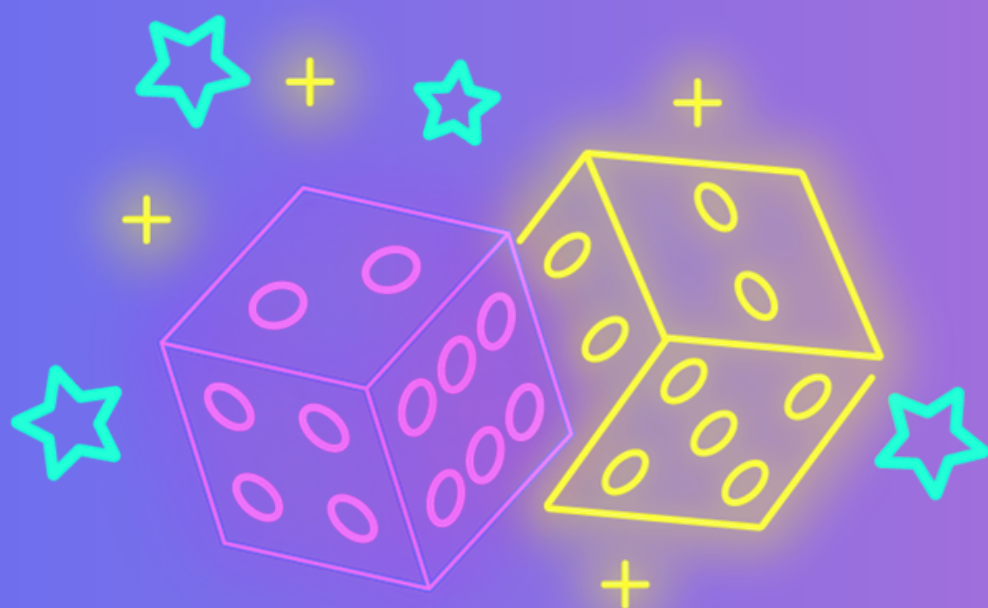


BREAKING THE ODDS

Consumer Behaviour Insights on Online Gambling Among Young Adults in Portugal

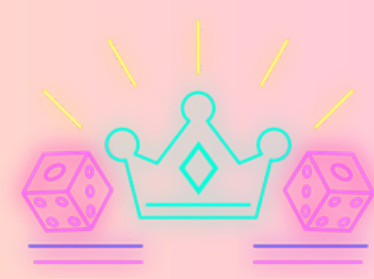
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INTRODUCTION

In recent years, the consumption landscape in Portugal has experienced a profound shift with the rise of online gambling, a phenomenon increasingly driven by the rapid digitalization of everyday entertainment and mobile financial systems. According to foundational research in consumer behavior, online platforms have detached traditional games of chance from physical venues, seamlessly embedding wagering into the daily routines and "dead time" of modern users. This digital transition is built upon a structural framework of 24/7 availability, operational speed, and unprecedented privacy (Gainsbury, 2015). From a consumer behavior standpoint, these specific attributes work together to lower both the friction and the cognitive barriers to entry. By fundamentally altering how young individuals perceive risk, anonymity, and personal control, this frictionless ecosystem has created an incredibly fertile ground for the widespread normalization of gambling practices across the country (Gainsbury, 2015; Hubert & Griffiths, 2018).

This reality became particularly acute following the comprehensive legislative regulation of the Portuguese online gaming sector in 2015 (Hubert & Griffiths, 2018). While gambling in Portugal was historically rooted in localized, physical activities like state lotteries, scratch cards, and casinos, the digital market experienced an unprecedented boom during the COVID-19 pandemic. In the first quarter of 2020 alone, online betting volumes in Portugal surged to €1,110 million, representing a striking 47.5% year-over-year increase in gross gaming revenue (Machado et al., 2021). Far from stabilizing after lockdowns ended, official metrics demonstrate a continuous and alarming expansion. Recent data from the Gambling Regulation and Inspection Service (SRIJ) reveals that national online gambling revenue hit a record €337.6 million in the final quarter of 2025, consolidating digital wagering not as a passing trend, but as a pervasive, mainstream consumer habit (SRIJ, 2025).

However, this macroeconomic boom masks a silent behavioral and public health crisis. The integration of seamless digital payment methods, most notably MBWay, has effectively removed the traditional "pain of paying" by converting hard currency into abstract numbers on a screen, which significantly accelerates impulsive, high-frequency spending (Gainsbury, 2015). When these digital routines bypass conscious self-regulation, they jeopardize basic well-being, disrupting the sleep, financial stability, and social lives of young consumers (Brevers & Noël, 2014). This threat is anchored in a striking structural paradox: while the gambling industry celebrates historical revenues, the number of individuals registered for voluntary self-exclusion in Portugal has hit an all-time high of 361,400 individuals (SRIJ, 2026). This issue is deeply aggravated by a lack of real-time monitoring and dedicated support frameworks within the country, leaving vulnerable users with very few immediate safety nets (Machado et al., 2021).

Young adults aged 18 to 34 are at the absolute center of this ecosystem, largely due to their constant exposure to algorithmic social media feeds, aggressive digital advertising, and mobile fintech solutions (Farias & Antunes, 2025). In Portugal, an intense sports culture heavily anchored in football has allowed sports betting to weave itself into youth socialization, turning a significant financial risk into a celebrated social ritual (Calado et al., 2020). Despite the visibility of this trend, we still lack a granular understanding of how deeply embedded this habit really is in their mindset.

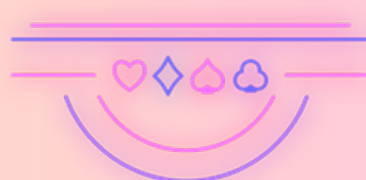
Consequently, this study is guided by a straightforward question: **How normalized is online gambling among young adults in Portugal?** To explore this, our project uses semi-structured interviews with 47 participants to analyze the lived experiences, individual rationalizations, and social perceptions of both active bettors and non-bettors. By gathering these firsthand qualitative insights, the primary goal of this research is to investigate the mechanisms that drive or restrict this normalization within youth social networks. Finally, to address the current gap in preventive infrastructure, this study evaluates how young Portuguese gamblers react to the prospective integration of Smart Health technologies, specifically investigating whether they would welcome or reject wearable devices designed to provide real-time biometric biofeedback, such as heart rate and stress alerts, during active betting sessions.

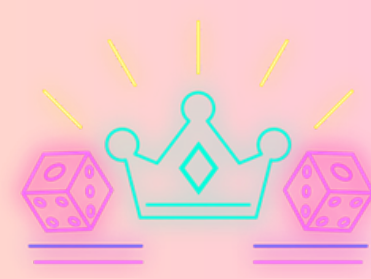
BACKGROUND

THE SHIFT FROM PHYSICAL TO DIGITAL GAMBLING

Games and gambling have been long-standing societal practices, with historical evidence tracing wagering as far back as the Hittites (4000 BC) and later as a state revenue source during the reigns of Queen Elizabeth and Queen Anne (McMillen, 1996). However, the gambling landscape has shifted radically from physical venues to the palm of the hand. As Gainsbury (2015) argues, this is not merely a change of scenery but a fundamental disruption of how people gamble. By removing the need for physical presence, online platforms have integrated betting into the "dead time" of daily life, what used to be a deliberate trip to a casino is now a private, immediate, and constant possibility.

In Portugal, this transition found fertile ground in a country with a long-standing relationship with offline games like the Lotaria Nacional and Placard. The digital market expanded rapidly following regulation, a trend accelerated by the COVID-19 pandemic. During confinement, while traditional casinos closed, Portugal saw over 435,000 active online players and a 47.2% spike in self-restriction requests (Machado et al., 2021).





THE PSYCHOLOGY OF FRICTIONLESS TRANSACTIONS

From a consumer behavior standpoint, the danger lies in how "frictionless" the digital gambling experience has become. The digitalization of money, especially through seamless local tools like MBWay, Revolut, and Apple Pay, creates a psychological disconnect between spending and consequence. When users are not handling physical cash, the "pain of paying" diminishes significantly: money feels less real, lowering the threshold for impulsive bets (Gainsbury, 2015). This reduced friction, combined with 24/7 accessibility and the absence of social observation, creates an environment where impulsive spending can escalate without immediate psychological resistance.

NEUROCOGNITIVE VULNERABILITY TO GAMBLING

The difficulty in resisting gambling is often the result of an imbalance between three key neurocognitive systems (Brevers & Noël, 2014). First, an overactive impulsive system drives immediate, automatic urges to gamble. Second, a weakened reflective system, responsible for self-control and weighing long-term consequences, fails to intervene effectively. Third, a sensory system monitors the body and interprets physical signals; when a spike in heart rate is read as excitement rather than warning, it reinforces the craving rather than triggering caution. Essentially, the body's physiological arousal overrides logical decision-making, making it difficult to stop through willpower alone.

This vulnerability is compounded by high comorbidity rates: a systematic meta-analysis by Lorains, Cowlishaw, and Thomas (2011) found that over 60% of individuals with gambling problems suffer from concomitant psychiatric conditions, including nicotine dependence (60.1%), substance use disorder (57.7%), mood disorders (37.9%), and anxiety disorders (37.4%).

FOOTBALL CULTURE AS A NORMALIZATION VEHICLE

In Portugal, an intense sports culture heavily anchored in football has allowed sports betting to weave itself into youth socialization. Unlike casino gambling, which carries social stigma, football betting benefits from association with a mainstream, celebrated activity. Club sponsorships, player endorsements, and in-match advertising have embedded betting brands into the fabric of the sport itself, transforming what is fundamentally a financial risk into a socially acceptable, even expected, ritual among young adults (Calado et al., 2020).

This process is consistent with Bandura's (1986) Social Cognitive Theory, which proposes that individuals acquire behavioral patterns through observational learning. When gambling is repeatedly modeled by trusted figures such as athletes, celebrities, and peers within a celebrated cultural context, young adults internalize positive outcome expectancies and normalize the behavior before ever consciously evaluating its risks.

THE REGULATORY GAP: SMART HEALTH INTERVENTIONS

Portuguese gambling legislation (Decree-Law 66/2015) established the legal framework for online gaming, focusing primarily on taxation, licensing, and technical compliance. While the regulation created a structured market, it offers limited harm-reduction mechanisms beyond voluntary self-exclusion. Notably absent is any consideration of "Smart Health" interventions, real-time biometric feedback systems that could alert users to physiological stress during active betting sessions.

Most young adults now wear devices capable of monitoring heart rate and stress levels. Yet it remains unclear whether gamblers notice these physiological signals during betting, or whether they would accept technological "nudges" to pause. This gap, between available wearable technology and its application in harm reduction, represents both a research opportunity and a policy blind spot that this study aims to address.

METHODOLOGY

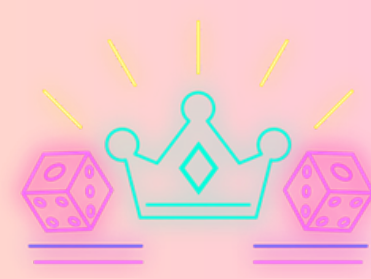
RESEARCH DESIGN & APPROACH

This study adopts a qualitative, exploratory, and interpretive research design to investigate the social and cultural normalization of online gambling among young adults in Portugal. Qualitative research is uniquely suited for this study as it is designed to explore the behavioral processes and cognitive rationalizations that drive consumer behavior (Gainsbury, 2015). Rather than measuring statistics, this approach seeks to interpret real-world phenomena through the lived experiences and opinions of the participants. By gathering data directly through one-on-one interactions, we captured rich, detailed perspectives on how gambling integrates into the daily lives of the target demographic.

SAMPLING STRATEGY & PARTICIPANT PROFILE

A convenience and purposive sampling strategy was employed to recruit participants. The study relied on volunteers from the authors' immediate networks, including family, friends, professional colleagues, and Nova IMS students.





No specific targeting was used regarding gender or gambling frequency; instead, these variables distributed naturally through fallout. The core inclusion criteria required participants to be between 18 and 36 years old and currently residing in Portugal. However, the final sample comprised 47 participants (aged 20 to 36) with a balanced split of approximately 50% active gamblers and 50% non-gamblers. This approach captured the internal behavioral processes of users alongside the external social perceptions, peer pressures, and environmental exposure observed by non-gamblers. The sample distributed naturally at approximately 40% female and 60% male.

DATA COLLECTION PROCESS

Data collection was executed within an academic window between May 5 and May 10. Prior to the official interviews, the script was refined under the guidance of the professor and pre-tested with individuals from the target demographic to ensure clarity, flow, and neutrality, preventing potential interviewer bias.

All 47 interviews were conducted remotely via Microsoft Teams using institutional Nova IMS accounts to leverage the platform's automated transcription tool. This sample size aligns with recommendations for thematic saturation in qualitative research, where saturation typically occurs between 12 and 30 interviews for homogeneous populations (Guest, Bunce & Johnson, 2006). Sessions lasted from 15 minutes to 1 hour, with a mean duration of 30 minutes, following a standardized protocol:

- The interviewer explicitly stated the academic purpose of the study and guaranteed strict data confidentiality.
- The interviewer formally announced that the session was being recorded for academic purposes. The participant provided explicit verbal consent on the record before any questions began.
- The semi-structured script was applied flexibly, moving from broader environmental aspects (advertising, football culture) to specific personal mechanics (payment methods, risk signals, and biometric innovations).

DATA ANALYSIS FRAMEWORK

The automated textual transcriptions from the recorded interviews were manually reviewed, cleaned, and cross-checked against the audio files for accuracy. The analysis followed a thematic coding approach using an inductive-deductive matrix (Coding Tree) that linked participant IDs to specific keywords allowed for the extraction of objective consumer insights from subjective discourse.

This framework allowed for the grouping of opinions per question, the identification of dominant trends, and the pinpointing of outlier perspectives. Through this matrix, benchmark comments were highlighted to best illustrate the empirical findings.

LIMITATIONS & ETHICAL CONSIDERATIONS

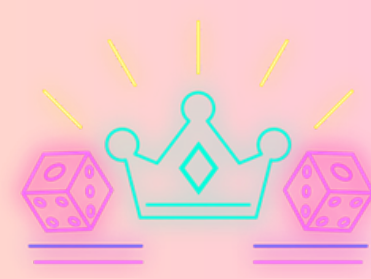
This study presents inherent limitations. The convenience sampling strategy may introduce selection bias, as participants from the authors' networks may share similar backgrounds. The sample also skews toward higher education (Nova IMS students), potentially limiting generalizability to the broader Portuguese youth population. Additionally, self-reported gambling behavior may be subject to social desirability bias regarding frequency and losses.

Ethically, guidelines were strictly prioritized. To protect participant privacy, all direct personal identifiers were removed, and participants were anonymized using ID numbers. In alignment with institutional data policies, all recordings are securely stored and will be permanently deleted after a mandatory retention period of three months.

FINDINGS

The data reveals that the majority of participants (91%) perceive that online gambling is either a fully normalized habit of daily life or that it is an activity becoming increasingly normalized in Portugal. Instead of being an isolated or hidden activity, online betting has become a normalized part of young adults' social routines. To understand the specific factors driving this widespread trend, the interview responses were analyzed based on key themes. The following sections present these findings, breaking down the environmental, social, technological, and psychological elements that have combined to lower the traditional barriers and perceived risks of gambling.





The primary channels of exposure identified were interpersonal and broadcast-based, with 89% of participants mentioning both friends and broadcast media, followed by targeted advertising (40%) and social media platforms (39%). This multi-platform saturation ensures that exposure is continuous rather than episodic. As Participant 11 noted, "I see betting ads on TV, during football streams, on Instagram, Facebook, and YouTube videos." The sense of inescapability was frequently emphasised: "From football to prime-time news, the exposure is constant. We are being completely bombarded with betting advertisements across all entertainment media" (Participant 4).

Several participants observed that this exposure begins well before adulthood. The majority reported first contact with gambling between the ages of 14 and 17, often through family practices such as scratch cards or the Euromillions: "Since forever my family all played Euromillions and Totoloto" (Participant 12).

2. FOOTBALL AS A KEY DRIVER OF BETTING NORMALIZATION

The intersection of football culture and betting emerged as one of the most significant findings, with 44 out of 47 participants highlighting the symbiotic relationship between football fandom and gambling platforms. Considering the cultural significance and social reach of football in Portugal, the persistent presence of betting brands within football contexts may intensify the normalization of online gambling and expand its social impact among young adults.

Participants consistently described betting not as an isolated activity but as a natural extension of being a football fan. The high visibility of betting brands within the sport, through sponsorships, club partnerships, player endorsements, and stadium advertising, embeds betting into the everyday experience of following football: "It's super straightforward, when you go to a football game, whether in the stands or on television, you see betting ads, signs on the pitch, and promotions linked to your club membership" (Participant 1). Participant 20 described this as a symbiotic relationship: "The fan stops being just a passive agent... because now there is something in the game."

Crucially, this association significantly alters the perception of gambling risk. Because football is a socially celebrated and mainstream activity, betting attached to it inherits its cultural legitimacy. Participants consistently distinguished football betting from casino gambling, not because the underlying financial risk differs, but because of its social framing: "People associate it with sports and entertainment instead of gambling itself. My friends often say betting on football is just for fun... while casinos are more directly associated with gambling environments" (Participant 33). Participant 6 described this perceived advantage as a "fictitious control" - the belief that sports knowledge translates into a genuine edge, when statistically the house always wins.

3. SOCIAL INFLUENCE

Peer influence emerged as a near-universal factor, with all participants acknowledging that friends and social groups significantly impact betting decisions. The research identified peer pressure as both a direct mechanism, friends actively encouraging bets, particularly around football matches, and an indirect one, through the fear of missing out. As Participant 41 observed: "I think it's very influential, especially because of the fear of missing out, which is something huge in our generation."

Social media influencers compound this dynamic by actively constructing an image of easy success and financial accessibility that resonates strongly with younger demographics. Participant 39 noted that "they promise easy money, which creates a sense of opportunity for younger people." A recurring and structurally important theme is the asymmetric communication of outcomes: participants consistently reported that social circles and online content amplify wins while losses remain invisible, producing a distorted perception of profitability and control. "Victories are much more prominently displayed than defeats, and this encourages people to say, 'If they can do it, we can too'" (Participant 6).

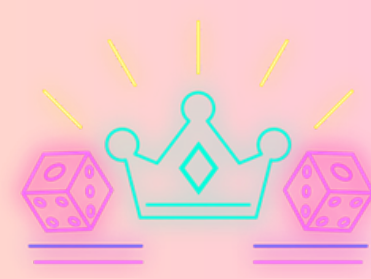
The cumulative effect of these dynamics creates a powerful feedback loop. Once betting becomes embedded in a social group's rituals, continued participation requires less conscious decision-making, the behaviour sustains itself through social reinforcement. As Participant 40 described: "If you're in this group and your friends talk about betting, you'll get that urge to want to get into it too."

4. DIGITAL ACCESS REDUCES BARRIERS AND ADDS IMPULSIVITY

All 47 participants noted that digital payment methods fundamentally alter the psychological experience of spending money on gambling. The seamless integration of tools such as MBWay, Revolut, and Apple Pay removes the "pain of paying", money becomes an abstract number rather than a tangible resource, lowering the threshold for impulsive deposits. As Participant 4 described: "It's the ease with which people open their phones, open the app and in three seconds make a transfer via MB Way, Revolut, QR Code or Apple Pay."

The absence of physical presence and social observation was equally significant. Without the friction of a physical environment, a cashier, a social gaze, a visible wallet emptying, impulsive spending can escalate without immediate resistance. Participant 13 captured this dynamic: "First, we don't have to have any human interaction... You don't feel any kind of judgment... you're very much there in your protected little cocoon."





These behavioural patterns are consistent with the neurocognitive framework proposed by Brevers and Noël (2014), in which an overactive impulsive system overrides the reflective system responsible for self-control and long-term consequence evaluation. In the digital gambling context, the absence of physical friction and social observation removes the environmental cues that might otherwise activate the reflective system, leaving impulsive urges largely unchecked.

Beyond payment friction, participants highlighted how platform design itself amplifies impulsivity. Betting apps send constant notifications and promotions, allow live in-play betting, and pre-select higher deposit amounts by default. Participant 38 described how Betclik's default deposit options begin at €50, meaning users consistently deposit more than intended. The result, as Participant 3 observed, is that "you are always receiving notifications and promotions and have immediate access to everything, you don't need to get in the car." The smartphone transforms betting from a deliberate act into a seamless, always-available habit.

5. CULTURE MASKS ADDICTION

The interviews reveal that 51% of participants perceive gambling as fully normalised in Portugal, while 40% view it as a rapidly growing phenomenon, and only 9% consider it non-problematic. This widespread acceptance is not merely a product of digital convenience but is reinforced by deep historical continuity and strategic commercial framing.

Participants frequently invoked Portugal's long tradition of state-sanctioned gambling, from Totobola to the Lotaria Nacional, as the cultural foundation upon which digital betting has expanded. As Participant 4 stated: "Betting has always been normal in Portugal. In the past it wasn't on platforms, but on Totobola and things like that. Now, with platforms, this has become easier." This historical familiarity lowers psychological resistance to online forms of the same behaviour.

This cultural normalisation is actively sustained by high-profile celebrity endorsements and institutional sponsorships that confer legitimacy upon gambling platforms. "Major public figures, like Cristina Ferreira, openly advertise it, which completely normalises the activity" (Participant 24). The use of harm-reduction slogans further obscures underlying risks: as Participant 29 observed, "We have a heavy betting culture disguised by phrases like 'gamble in moderation.' Young adults increasingly view gambling not as a risk, but as a legitimate strategy for extra income."

When this cultural mask slips, the consequences become visible. Participants identified a clear set of behavioural markers signalling the transition from recreational betting to problematic gambling: the compulsive need to recover losses, borrowing money from friends and family, and betting on unfamiliar markets simply to sustain the cycle. Participant 3 described the tipping point clearly: "When a person starts to have financial problems and starts borrowing money from others to be able to bet, or when they try to recover their losses... if you have 250 euros to pay the rent and put the 250 euros into a game, you are using that money as a form of addiction." This escalation pattern also reflects the sensory dimension of neurocognitive vulnerability described by Brevers and Noël (2014): physiological arousal during active betting, elevated heart rate, heightened attention, tends to be interpreted as excitement rather than warning, reinforcing the compulsive cycle rather than triggering caution. The high comorbidity rates documented in the literature further contextualise these findings, with Lorains, Cowlshaw and Thomas (2011) identifying that over 60% of individuals with gambling problems present concomitant psychiatric conditions, suggesting that what participants describe as loss of control is rarely an isolated behavioural phenomenon.

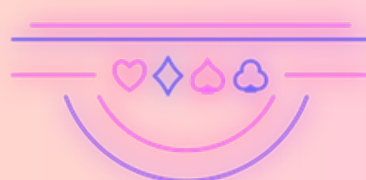
Regarding digital guardrails, participant feedback was mixed: while some saw value in biometric or spending-limit interventions, 34% remained sceptical. As Participant 30 noted, "I don't think it's this app or this pop-up that's going to make you want to stop. Stopping any addiction comes much more from the person themselves than from applications."

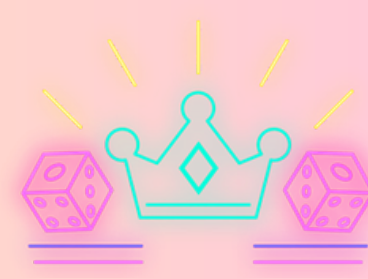
INSIGHTS

1. PARTICIPANTS EXPRESSED THAT GAMBLING NORMALIZATION BEGINS LONG BEFORE ANY ACTIVE DECISION TO BET

Extrapolating the empirical findings to young adults in Portugal demonstrates that for the vast majority, the normalization of online gambling is a cumulative, long-term process that occurs long before an individual makes an active, conscious decision to place a bet. Participants specifically highlighted experiencing exposure as young children while witnessing the gambling habits of their loved ones. This early exposure, combined with continuous contact with a high volume of pervasive media through football sponsorships, prime-time television, and social media platforms, transforms gambling from an unfamiliar financial risk into a routine, recognizable element of daily life. As several participants observed, this exposure occurs so repeatedly and from such an early age that gambling feels familiar and routine before any conscious choice is made.

This human action can be profoundly explained through the lens of Albert Bandura's Social Cognitive Theory (SCT), specifically the mechanism of observational learning (Bandura, 1986). Bandura proposes that individuals acquire behavioral patterns by observing the actions of others and the environmental cues surrounding them. When young adults are repeatedly exposed to gambling narratives from an early age—often starting within the family structure via traditional state games like scratch cards or the Euromillions—they undergo a process of cognitive structuring. Because the behavior is visible, socially accepted, and consistently modeled by trusted figures (such as family members, sports icons, and mainstream media), young adults internalize positive outcome expectancies. They learn to associate the act of wagering with rewards, entertainment, and social bonding before ever interacting with a digital betting application.





Furthermore, evaluating the psychological mechanics of a habit loop, it is evident that routines require a recurring trigger to sustain themselves. The contemporary digital and media ecosystem in Portugal acts as an ambient, unavoidable trigger network. As Participant 38 reflected, repeated exposure eventually dissolves the capacity to critically evaluate the behavior. This confirms that normalization is not the result of a single decision point, but of a cumulative, largely unconscious process embedded in everyday media consumption. Consequently, normalization precedes active participation because the environment provides a continuous loop of triggers that naturally integrates gambling into the consumer's subconscious social routines.

2. PARTICIPANTS IDENTIFIED FOOTBALL AS A CULTURAL MECHANISM THAT SEPARATES BETTING FROM ITS PERCEIVED RISK

The empirical findings demonstrate that football acts as a powerful cultural mechanism that cognitively dissociates online betting from its inherent financial risks. Participants consistently distinguished sports wagering from traditional casino gambling. This distinction is rooted in the emotional familiarity and societal celebration surrounding football culture. As Participant 33 noted, peer groups routinely frame football betting as "just for fun," while isolating casino games as predatory environments.

When betting is embedded within football, it inherits the sport's cultural legitimacy. This creates a psychological "risk-shielding" effect where the positive, communal associations consumers hold toward football project onto the wagering platform, transforming the perception of financial risk into an act of sports fandom.

Additionally, the data captures a distinct cognitive bias within youth consumer behavior. Participant 6 conceptualized this as a "fictitious control," where consumers mistakenly believe that their subjective sports knowledge or team statistics grant them a genuine advantage over traditional gambling in casinos. Because young adults believe they can predict match outcomes based on expertise, they perceive the behavior as highly controllable, which dramatically lowers the perceived risk of placing a bet.

3. PARTICIPANTS REPORTED THAT SOCIAL BELONGING, NOT FINANCIAL MOTIVATION, IS THE PRIMARY ENTRY POINT INTO GAMBLING

Analyzing the interview data unraveled that social belonging, rather than immediate financial motivation, serves as the primary entry point into online gambling for young adults. Multiple participants described initiating betting behaviors not out of an independent desire for money, but to participate in peer conversations, maintain social alignment, and avoid feeling excluded. As Participant 39 noted, shared living and social environments create an atmosphere where peers naturally "end up betting together in everyday life," turning a financial activity into a collective social ritual.

This dynamic is heavily accelerated by the Fear of Missing Out (FOMO), a powerful psychological trigger in youth consumer behavior. When betting becomes a staple of a peer group's routines, non-participating individuals experience a distinct social anxiety regarding both missing out on shared experiences and the potential rewards celebrated by the group. Participant 41 highlighted the speed of this social assimilation, noting it would "probably only take two or three times hanging out" with betting friends before an individual succumbs to the pressure and joins the activity to maintain group cohesion.

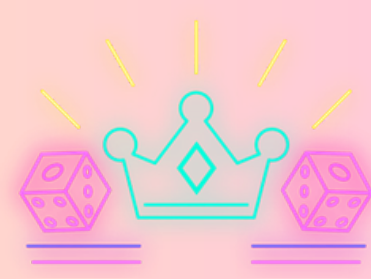
Furthermore, this social pressure is compounded by a stark asymmetry in peer communication. Participants consistently reported that successful wagers circulate visibly and loudly within social networks, while financial losses remain entirely invisible. This selective sharing distorts the consumer's perception of reality, manufacturing a false impression of consistent profitability and easy success. Driven by FOMO and surrounded by a biased, positive feedback loop of wins, young adults face significantly reduced psychological barriers, making entry into gambling feel like a necessary step for social inclusion.

4. PARTICIPANTS CALLED FOR STRICTER ADVERTISING REGULATION AS THE MOST URGENT STRUCTURAL CHANGE

A compelling pattern that emerged in the analysis is the spontaneous demand of participants for stricter regulatory control over the gambling industry. Without interviewers prompting participants, these young adults consistently shifted the conversation to criticize the current marketing landscape as aggressive and predatory. This consensus highlights a deep consumer preoccupation, where individuals actively recognize that the digital advertising ecosystem exploits young adults and teenagers. They note that promotional campaigns intentionally leverage psychological vulnerabilities through constant exposure, peer pressure, and FOMO.

This cognitive insight aligns closely with debates in consumer protection policy regarding the social side effects of industries and the implementation of user safety measures. Portugal's legislation on gambling, under Article 21 of the Advertising Code, has been viewed as more permissive than the sweeping restrictions found in several other European nations. Participants frequently compared the ubiquity of gambling advertisements to other restricted industries, with Participant 30 noting it was "unbelievable" that digital betting is not legislated in the same manner as tobacco.





This comparison demonstrates that young consumers do not view online betting as a harmless entertainment product, but as an addictive substance requiring direct state-level intervention. Suggestions varied from total prohibitions (Participant 46) and restricting broadcasts to late-night hours (Participant 2), to banning high-profile celebrity endorsements (Participant 35).

Furthermore, these participant-proposed solutions reveal a clear understanding of the limitations of individual self-control in frictionless digital environments. Rather than relying solely on personal willpower, participants advocated for structural friction, such as Participant 29's proposal for a spending cap system tied directly to income verification. This demand for top-down regulation indicates that while young adults are deeply immersed in a normalized gambling culture, they experience intense internal conflict regarding its safety. They are actively calling for systemic, governmental barriers to artificially aid consumers in avoiding or decreasing gambling addiction.

5. PARTICIPANTS EXPRESSED DEEP SCEPTICISM ABOUT TECHNOLOGICAL SOLUTIONS AS STANDALONE RESPONSES TO ADDICTION

Besides criticizing the legislation restrictions on gambling exposure, the responses also revealed a deep skepticism toward standalone technological features as effective solutions for gambling addiction. When evaluating potential wearable interventions, such as smartwatch notifications or biometric stress alerts, the vast majority of participants, including active bettors, reported that they would simply ignore or dismiss the prompts. This dismissive behavior highlights how repetitive automated warnings lose their psychological impact and are filtered out by the consumer as mere background noise. As Participant 30 noted, despite wearing a smartwatch that actively prompts him to stop certain behaviors, he could "count on his fingers" the rare moments he actually complied.

This resistance can be explained when looking at how our brains process decisions, through the Dual-Process Theory, which points out that human decision-making is governed by two cognitive systems: a fast, subconscious, and impulsive "System 1" and a slow, deliberate, and rational "System 2." In the context of digital gambling, the frictionless design of betting apps keeps the consumer heavily locked into an automated System 1 state. Participant 21 accurately stated that overcoming gambling requires real psychological support rather than a digital device. A brief smartwatch alert is just too weak to break that impulsive autopilot loop and force a user to switch over to their rational System 2 thinking.

Additionally, the data reveals that young adults perceive a much higher value in having financial transparency features over biometric alerts. Participant 12 suggested that displaying a user's cumulative losses over time, mirroring the spending summaries already popularized by modern banking applications, would be significantly more effective than stress notifications. From a behavioral economics perspective, visualizing aggregate financial loss reintroduces the psychological friction that digital payment methods typically erase. By forcing consumers to confront the concrete, long-term financial consequences of their actions, transparent tracking shocks the consumer out of autopilot, directly engaging System 2 rational awareness to prompt a realistic evaluation of the behavior.

IMPLICATIONS

The findings of this study carry implications across three levels: practical, policy, and theoretical.

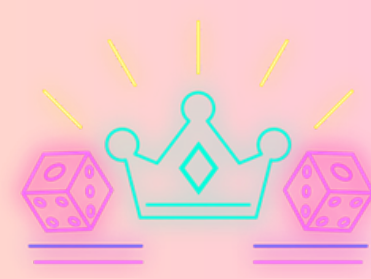
PRACTICAL IMPLICATIONS

Given that normalization appears to begin long before adulthood, harm-reduction efforts may benefit from being directed upstream. Embedding financial literacy programs and awareness initiatives within secondary education could help reach adolescents before behavioral conditioning is fully established. Since participants indicated that social belonging, rather than financial motivation, tends to drive entry into gambling, interventions that address peer dynamics may prove more effective than those centered solely on individual risk awareness. Additionally, as participants expressed greater receptiveness to financial transparency tools than to biometric alerts, platform designers might consider prioritizing cumulative loss summaries, similar to those already found in banking applications, as a way of reintroducing psychological friction into the betting experience.

POLICY IMPLICATIONS

Participants spontaneously compared Portugal's advertising landscape to more restrictive frameworks in countries such as Spain, Italy, and the United Kingdom, suggesting that extending regulations to digital platforms, revisiting celebrity endorsement practices, and considering watershed rules for gambling advertisements could be worthwhile areas for policy discussion. The football-betting relationship also emerged as a particularly significant normalization pathway in participants' accounts, indicating that the role of betting sponsorships within professional football may deserve closer regulatory consideration.





THEORETICAL IMPLICATIONS

This study offers qualitative support for Bandura's (1986) Social Cognitive Theory in the gambling normalization context, suggesting that observational learning may function as a pre-decisional conditioning mechanism. The findings also appear consistent with the Dual-Process Theory framework, indicating that frictionless platform design may systematically reduce the engagement of rational System 2 thinking. Finally, the skepticism toward biometric interventions expressed by participants invites further reflection on the assumptions underlying Smart Health research, pointing to the possibility that technological nudges may need to be accompanied by structural and psychological support to produce meaningful behavioral change.

CONCLUSION

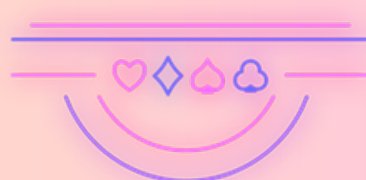
This study set out to investigate how cultural normalization drives the high popularity of online gambling among young adults in Portugal. The findings consistently point to a phenomenon that is structural rather than individual, normalization is not the result of personal weakness or isolated choices, but of an ecosystem in which advertising, football culture, social dynamics, and frictionless digital access work together to make betting feel ordinary before it is ever consciously evaluated.

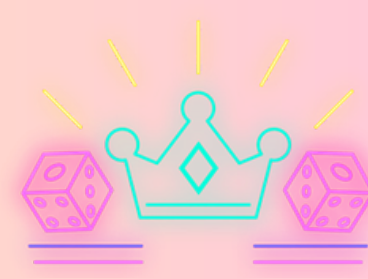
Exposure begins in childhood and accelerates through adolescence, meaning that by the time young adults encounter online betting platforms, the behaviour already carries cultural familiarity. Football amplifies this process by lending gambling its social legitimacy, while peer groups sustain it through visibility of wins and invisibility of losses. Digital payment systems remove the final psychological barriers, transforming betting from a deliberate act into a seamless habit embedded in daily life.

Taken together, these mechanisms reveal a significant gap between how gambling is perceived, as entertainment, social participation, or a skill-based activity, and what it structurally is: a financially asymmetric system in which the house always wins. Addressing this gap requires moving beyond individual responsibility. As participants themselves made clear, the most urgent interventions are structural: stricter regulation of advertising, greater transparency around financial losses, and a cultural reckoning with the normalisation that institutional endorsement and celebrity promotion have made possible.

STATEMENT

Paulo, Mariana, Adriana, Melissa contributed more to the overall project, with Paulo, Mariana, and Melissa having contributed the most for the whole project, while Hiba, Dinara and Ebru were less proactive and contributed less.





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APPENDIX

INTERVIEW SCRIPT

Introduction and Consent

"Hello, thank you for agreeing to participate. I am conducting a study for NOVA IMS about the presence and normalization of online betting within youth culture in Portugal. I would like to hear your perspective on this social phenomenon, regardless of whether you are a bettor or not. This conversation is confidential, and the recording will only be used for transcription and academic analysis purposes. Do you agree?"

"Thank you very much. Let's begin. First, I would like to ask you a few questions about yourself:"

I. Participant Profile

- **Age:**
- **Gender:**
- **Occupation:** (Student, worker, both, other)
- **Experience:** Have you ever used an online betting platform or placed a digital bet?

Survey Questions

1. In your opinion, how does the "betting culture" manifest itself in Portugal today?
2. Why do you think betting has become so common among young adults in Portugal?
3. In your daily life, in which places or moments do you usually notice the presence of advertising or references to online betting?
4. **QUANTITATIVE** – How often does the topic of betting usually appear in your life (e.g., football, friends, social media, advertising)?
5. **QUANTITATIVE** – At what age would you say you were exposed to gambling or betting for the first time?
6. In what ways do you feel there is a greater incentive for online betting today compared to the past?
7. **QUANTITATIVE FOR BETTORS/GAMBLERS** – How often do you usually bet?
8. **QUANTITATIVE** – "How much do you think the decision to bet online is influenced by friends or social groups?"
9. **QUANTITATIVE** – How many of your friends bet regularly?
10. How would you describe the current relationship between "being a football fan" and using betting platforms?
11. In your opinion, why is betting on a football match viewed differently from other games of chance (casinos or other)?
12. How does using methods like MBWay and banking apps alter the perception of the value of money spent, compared to physical cash?
13. In what ways does using online apps influence the motivation and ease of betting?
14. **FOR BETTORS/GAMBLERS** – What is your typical process or routine when you decide to place a bet?
15. Tell me about what you consider to be the signs that someone is losing control over their betting behavior.
16. Nowadays, there is a lot of talk about using Artificial Intelligence or algorithms to help predict betting results. What are your thoughts on using these types of tools?
17. What is your opinion on the idea of a device (such as a Smartwatch) intervening during a betting session to suggest a break due to stress?

18-Closing question

"Thank you very much for your time and your contribution to this study. Before we finish, is there anything else you consider important regarding online gambling, cultural normalization, football culture, advertising, or risk perception that we haven't covered?"

AGE DISTRIBUTION OF THE SAMPLE

